



THE FACTORY GAME STARTER GUIDE

Which game fits your brain, what to skip, and how
to dodge the first 10 hours of mistakes

By Manu Games

The Assembly Line Newsletter

2026 edition · every price & version current to June 2026

Start Here: the 60-second pick

Skip the 18-item listicles. The genre really only forks on a few things you already know about yourself. Find your row, start there, and read the rest of the guide once you're hooked.

If this is you...	Start with...	Why
You want calm. No enemies, no survival, just logic.	Shapez 2	Pure shape-routing puzzle. The gentlest on-ramp in the genre.
You want to walk around your factory in 3D.	Satisfactory	First-person and forgiving, the most beginner-friendly big builder.
You want the deepest, most respected factory sim.	Factorio (Peaceful)	The genre's gold standard. Peaceful mode removes the combat.
You want to play free, or on your phone or Steam Deck.	Mindustry	Free, runs anywhere, the only true pocket factory game here.
You want spectacle: build across planets, around a star.	Dyson Sphere Program	Jaw-dropping scale, but slow to start. Not your first if you're impatient.
You want to dig, tunnel and terraform a voxel world.	Foundry	First-person, fully destructible terrain. Build straight down.

Torn between Satisfactory and Factorio? The 30-second test.

Both are perfect first games; they just teach differently. **Want to feel it**, walk through your factory, admire it, get lost in a world? **Satisfactory**. **Want to learn it**, the cleanest cause-and-effect, the best tutorial, the purest logistics brain-teaser? **Factorio on Peaceful** (turns off the bugs so you build in peace). If you can't decide, Satisfactory is the softer landing.

The 2026 Snapshot

Factory games run on one of the most addictive loops in gaming: gather, build, automate, and watch the whole thing hum while you plan the next expansion. Hand-mining ore becomes a symphony of belts, arms and logistics that runs while you sleep. If you feel the pull, this guide tells you exactly where to start.

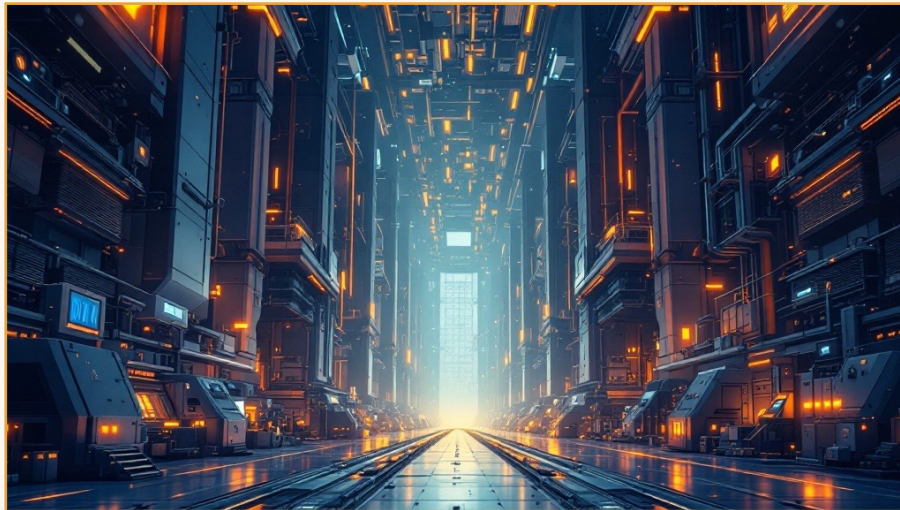
Why right now is the best time to start

The genre just had its biggest few months ever. Most of the major games shipped landmark updates this spring, so whatever you buy today, you get its best version yet:

When	What shipped	The short version
Jun 2, 2026	Satisfactory: 1.2 stable + cross-platform	Weather, vehicle rework, fluid trucks. Now on PC, PS5 and Xbox at once.
Apr 28, 2026	Foundry: Update 4, Rails and Reactors	Trains, construction drone, 360 MW Xeno reactor.
Apr 23, 2026	Shapez 2: 1.0 release	Left Early Access: Manufacture mode, Workshop, 80+ achievements.
Apr 2026	Mindustry: v8	First big release since 2022. Free, and now great on mobile.
Apr 2, 2026	Modulus: Factory Automation 1.0	New and beginner-friendly, 91% positive. Design your own modules.
~late Jun	Factorio: 2.1, the final feature update	Last big content patch before Wube moves to maintenance.

Translation: anything you buy this month gets the biggest, freshest version of that game. There has never been a better time to pick one up.

The Genre, Mapped



First, a distinction that saves you a bad purchase. **Automation games** (Factorio, Dyson Sphere) hand you a sandbox and a problem to optimize forever, the joy is the optimizing. **Goal-driven factory games** (Satisfactory, Foundry) give you milestones and a finish line. Neither is better; they scratch different itches. Then it forks into four flavors:

1. Logistics & automation (top-down)

The classic. See the factory from above, design belt layouts, balance ratios, scale from a few machines to a megabase. Factorio wrote the playbook; Dyson Sphere put it in space; Mindustry put it under siege.

Key games: Factorio, Dyson Sphere Program, Mindustry

2. 3D building & exploration (first-person)

Walk through your factory and build in three dimensions, verticality, open-world exploration, architectural scale. Your factory isn't a diagram, it's a place.

Key games: Satisfactory, Foundry, Captain of Industry, StarRupture

3. Abstract & puzzle (shape-based)

Strip away combat and scarcity. Route shapes through machines, cutting, painting, stacking. Factory games for people who love pure logic puzzles.

Key games: Shapez 2, Modulus: Factory Automation

4. Factory + twist (the new wave)

2025-26 minted new sub-genres: **programmable factories** (Kaizen, The Farmer Was Replaced) where you write logic instead of placing belts, plus factory roguelikes and falling-sand factories. The formula still has new shapes left.

Key games: Kaizen, The Farmer Was Replaced, Sandustry

The Comparison Matrix

Seven games, head-to-head, the table no listicle will give you. Prices are base Steam US (June 2026). "Time to click" is how long until the loop genuinely grabs you, not how long to finish. Learning curve is 1 (gentle) to 5 (brutal).

Game	Combat	Curve	Time to click	Co-op	Price
Factorio (+Space Age)	Optional (Peaceful)	5	~1 hr	Yes	\$35 +\$35 DLC
Satisfactory	Minimal	3	2-3 hrs	1-16	\$40
Shapez 2	None	2	1-2 hrs	Solo	\$30
Dyson Sphere Program	Optional	4	~10 hrs	Solo	\$20
Mindustry	Core (tower def.)	3	2-3 hrs	Yes	Free (~\$3 iOS)
Foundry (EA)	None	3	3-5 hrs	1-8	\$30
Captain of Industry	None	5	5-10 hrs	Solo	\$35

Platforms, Steam Deck & value

	Best handheld	Best on-the-go	Best \$ / hour	Fastest to fun
Winner	Satisfactory	Mindustry	Mindustry	Factorio
Why	Only Deck-Verified; plays like console	Free on phone + Deck; truly portable	Free, or DSP: \$20 for 200+ hrs	Loop clicks in under an hour

2026 arrivals: wishlist, don't start here (yet)

StarRupture (Creepy Jar, 82%), ambitious co-op survival-factory, but Early Access with microscopic, unscalable text. **Modulus: Factory Automation** (91%, \$25), a lovely calm module-builder worth watching, just very new. Both are bets, not first picks. Wishlist them and grab one on a Steam sale.

Play This If... (and don't, if...)

Factorio + Space Age

Play this if the deepest, most-respected factory game ever made and you want the genre's purest puzzle. Space Age adds four planets. Base is 98% Overwhelmingly Positive across 230,000+ reviews. 2.1, the final feature update, lands this summer.

Don't start here if you're impatient with menus or you want it cheap, the full modern experience is \$70.

Satisfactory

Play this if you want to walk through your factory in first person and explore between builds. Best multiplayer in the genre, and the only game here that's Steam-Deck Verified. 1.2 just shipped on PC, PS5 and Xbox simultaneously.

Don't start here if you want a top-down optimizer, this is a builder you live inside, not a spreadsheet.

Shapez 2

Play this if you want the puzzle without the survival, no enemies, no scarcity, just shape logic. 1.0 shipped April 2026 with Manufacture mode and Workshop. The single best entry point in the genre.

Don't start here if you crave a living world, it's deliberately abstract and clean.

Dyson Sphere Program

Play this if you want Factorio-depth with breathtaking visuals, building a sphere around a star is one of gaming's great endgames. The best value on this list (\$20 for 200+ hours).

Don't start here if it's your first one, the opening ~10 hours are slow and menu-heavy. Earn it second.

Mindustry

Play this if you want to try the genre for free, or play on your phone or Steam Deck. A tower-defense / factory hybrid, free on PC and Android, ~\$3 on iOS. The lowest-risk way to find out if factory games are for you.

Don't start here if you want pure building with no pressure, the combat is the point here.

Foundry

Play this if you want first-person building plus the freedom to dig, tunnel and reshape the voxel terrain. Update 4 added trains. Published by Paradox.

Don't start here if you need polish, it's Early Access and the UI is still rough.

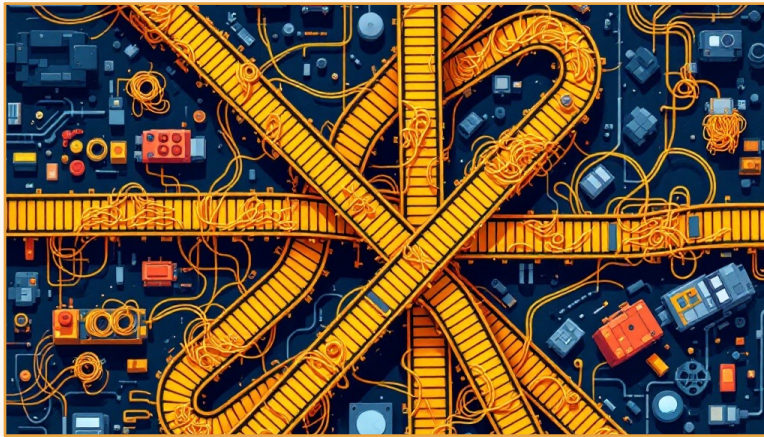
Captain of Industry

Play this if you want factory-building plus colony management, people, farming, vehicle logistics, all stacked on the loop. The most complex game here.

Don't start here if you're new to the genre. It's a management sim wearing a factory costume, and the dev team confirmed 2-4 more years of Early Access. Start somewhere gentler.

5 Mistakes That Wreck Your First Factory

These wreck a first base in any of these games. Every veteran made them. Learn from our collective pain.



Your first factory. And that is exactly how it should look.

Mistake #1: Building your "forever base" in hour one

Every one of these games hides the true late-game scale from a new player, so the tidy base you lovingly place becomes a demolition job. The veteran consensus is identical across Factorio, Satisfactory and the rest: build a deliberately **disposable scaffold** to escape the early game, then build the real factory next door with the better tools you've unlocked. This isn't "automate early", it's **permission to build ugly and throw it away**. Your first base is supposed to be spaghetti, that's the genre working as intended.

Mistake #2: Blaming the machine when it's the belt

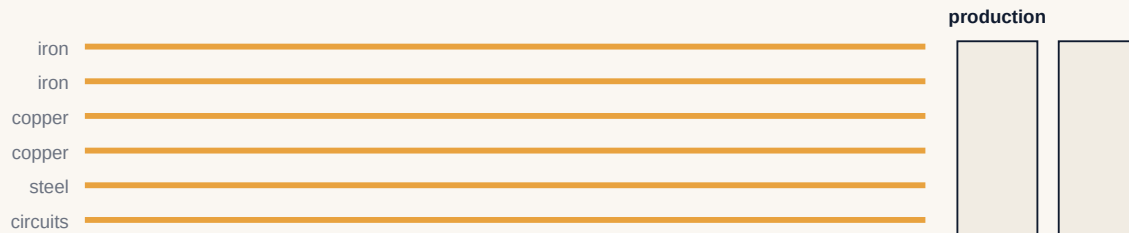
When production drops, new players ask "what machine am I missing?" The real culprit is almost always **flow**: a belt or pipe that can't keep up after you bolted on more machines, a line backed up by unwanted output with nowhere to dump (Shapez 2's off-cuts, Factorio's overflow), or a supply consumed faster than it's fed. The mindset fix: **when output stalls, suspect the belt before the building**. Upgrade the feeding line, add a trash/overflow lane, or match your inserter and belt tiers (a basic inserter literally flails trying to pull off a fast belt).

Mistake #3: Overbuilding "to be safe"

Counterintuitively, building *too much* early hurts as much as too little. A thousand idle furnaces, a surplus of excavators, extra pumps, none of them just sit there politely; they **eat the exact construction materials you're short on**. The discipline: build to current throughput and scale a line only when it's visibly starved, not preemptively.

Mistake #4: No main bus (or one that's too narrow to grow)

At some point spaghetti hits a wall: materials can't reach where they're needed. The fix is a **main bus**, a few wide lanes of your most-used materials running through the base, tapped off to feed production. The trap is building it too narrow, then trying to widen it (which means re-routing everything). Lay it generously from the start and inject *more* production into existing lanes later, don't add lanes.



The main bus: a few wide lanes of your most-used materials, tapped off to feed production. Leave 2-tile gaps, and add throughput into existing lanes rather than bolting on new ones later.

Mistake #5: Staying manual too long

Hand-crafting items, hand-feeding machines, running materials back and forth, it *feels* productive, but you're the bottleneck. The whole point is to automate yourself out of a job. Every time you catch yourself doing something repetitive, ask: can a machine do this? The answer is almost always yes. A slow automated line beats a fast manual one because it works while you plan the next expansion.

The meta-mistake

Watching 20-hour optimization tutorials before you've played. Every game here has a YouTube rabbit hole, **don't go in yet**. Play 4-5 hours blind first; the discoveries you make on your own are the genre's main pleasure, and the tutorials will still be there once you understand what they're solving.

Your First Hour, Per-Game Crib Sheets

Get past the cold-start moment, then learn the rest by doing. One "wish I'd known" gem per game, the kind veterans only learn 30 hours in.

Factorio

Do: burner drills on iron + copper into stone furnaces → small steam power (1 pump : 4 boilers : 8 engines) → research Automation → hand-feed red science into a couple of labs → swap to electric drills → lay a main bus (4 iron, 4 copper, 2-tile gaps). **Wish I'd known:** learn the pipette (Q) and copy-paste / blueprints early, players play 40 hours before discovering Q picks whatever you point at.

Satisfactory

Do: power the HUB → Miner Mk.1 on iron → Smelter → Constructor for plates/rods → hold Spacebar to auto-craft → a Biomass Burner off leaves/wood carries power until coal. **Wish I'd known:** your first base is a disposable scaffold, build it messy and fast to blow through the early tiers, then build the pretty one next door once Foundations and blueprints unlock.

Shapedz 2

Do: stay in Classic mode, make squares and circles via Cutter / Rotator / Stacker / Painter, Shift-drag long belts, max your upgrades before finishing a delivery, and run a trash lane from the start. **Wish I'd known:** don't make your first MAM ambitious, isolate one part, route it, output it reliably, then expand. For wires, start with a Belt Filter, it's the one with a visible result.

Dyson Sphere Program

Do: scout the start (iron/copper/coal/stone are usually clustered, don't travel yet), keep the Icarus mech fueled, wind turbines for power, automate magnets / coils / circuit boards / gears, then Matrix Labs on blue science. **Wish I'd known:** never fly to a new planet without fuel and supplies in your pocket, the signature beginner pain is crawling across an alien world with a dead mech.

Foundry

Do: follow Carl's tutorial (it gates recipes), mine Xenoferrite + Technum, lay foundations, smelters, a research server for science packs, drone miners feeding smelters with loaders aligned to each machine's I/O. **Wish I'd known:** it's a 3D game, think in height, not a 2D grid. Stack production vertically, and ore veins are deep underground deposits you unlock with research.

Captain of Industry

Do: iron smelter + Construction Parts, then Vehicle Depot, Trading Dock, a Generator, and two Farms before anything fancy. Get self-sustaining concrete going (the usual early bottleneck) and start coal early. **Wish I'd known:** keep your population alive and build storage everywhere, the game punishes premature optimization far more than a messy-but-stable base. You'll redesign later anyway.

The Idle On-Ramp

Love the loop but not the four-hour sessions? Idle and incremental games deliver the same progression high in bursts you can pick up and put down, and the genre is having a moment. These are the picks worth your time right now, weighted to the recent releases the rest of the internet hasn't caught up to.



Kaizen: A Factory Story

Assembly-line automation as a tidy puzzle, from a lead designer of Zachtronics (Opus Magnum, Shenzhen I/O). The cleanest bridge from factory games to idle: it *is* a factory game, just played in calm, bite-size sessions.

\$20 · PC/Mac/Linux · 92% Very Positive

The Farmer Was Replaced

Idle farming where you write Python-like scripts to automate a drone instead of clicking. 96% Overwhelmingly Positive across 8,500+ reviews; a "Miner Was Replaced" follow-up is on the way.

\$10 · PC

Unnamed Space Idle

A deep, free, long-form sci-fi idler, 10+ interlocking systems that scratch the factory-optimization itch with none of the real-time belt-wrangling. The pick if you want depth that genuinely runs in the background.

Free · PC/Linux · 92% Very Positive

Berry Bury Berry

2026's breakout incremental: a first-person oddity about growing berries and tossing them down an ominous hole. 98% Overwhelmingly Positive and climbing.

\$8 · PC · 98% Overwhelmingly Positive

Legends of Dragaea: Idle Dungeons

A first-person idle dungeon-crawler, party expeditions, a classless skill system and guild management all ticking while you idle. The most literal *idle RPG* on this page, and the natural stepping-stone to what's next.

\$10 · PC / Steam Deck · 87% Very Positive

Melvor Idle

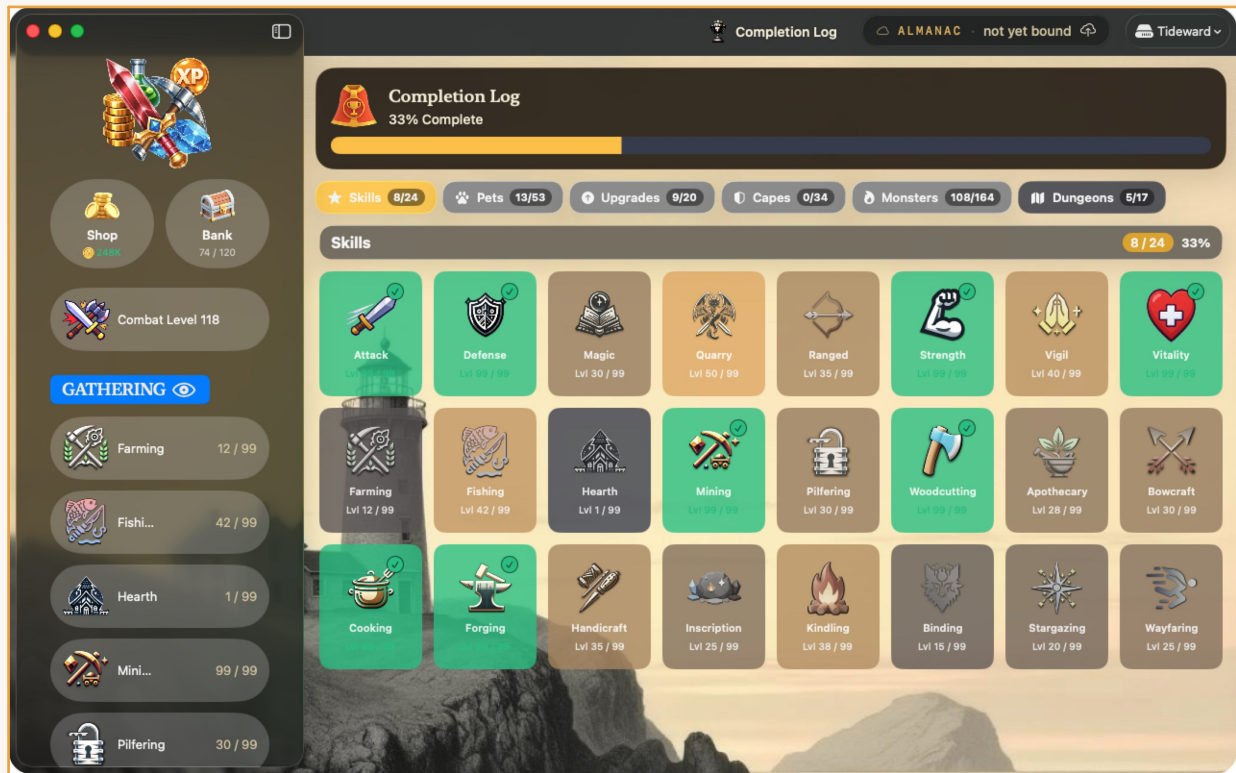
The genre's gold-standard premium model, free-to-start, \$9.99 unlock, optional \$4.99 expansions, no microtransactions. Published by Jagex. Melvor Idle 2 is targeting Steam Early Access in 2026.

Free to start · PC, iOS, Android, browser

The classics, briefly: **Synergism** (free on browser & Steam), **Antimatter Dimensions** (free; gold-standard prestige math), **Bitburner** (free; program your way up), **Cookie Clicker**, **NGU Idle** and **Nodebuster**. Direct links in the Links section.

Inside Look: Tideward

Full disclosure: I'm building this one. If that last section walked you from factory loops toward idle RPGs, Tideward is where that road leads, the idle RPG I've spent two-plus years on at Manu Games, and the whole reason this newsletter exists.



Tideward on Mac: the full almanac of trades, one tap away.

What it is

A skill-based idle RPG, native on every Apple device, where you train trades, fight monsters and gather resources while you go about your day. The depth of a full RPG, compressed into a format that respects your time: **20+ trades** across combat (melee / ranged / magic), gathering and crafting, Bronze-through-Dragon gear, each trade with its own path.

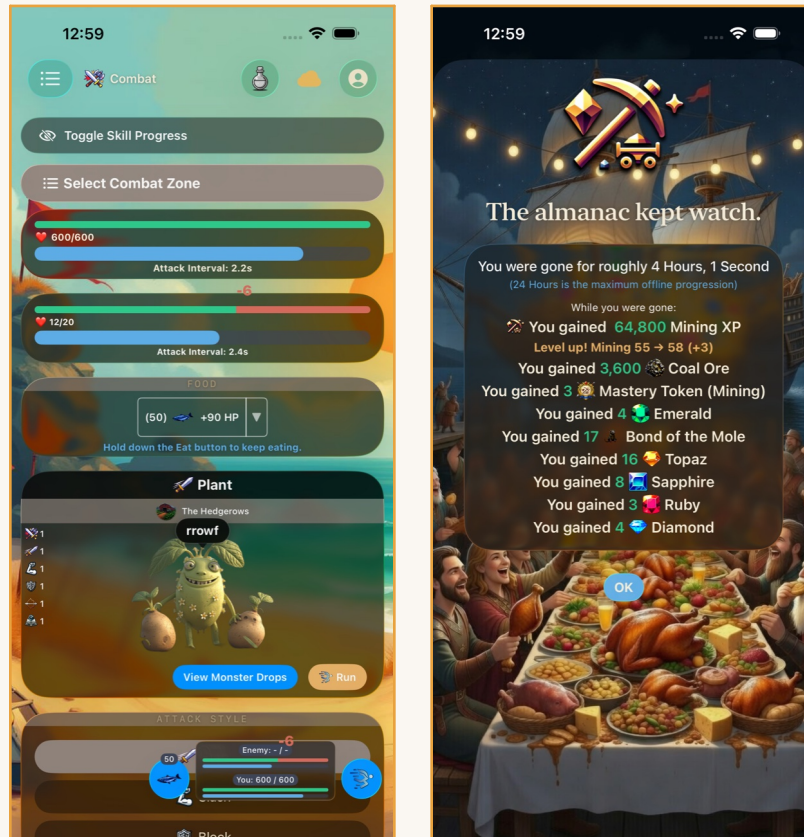
What makes it different

- **Built for Apple, not ported to it.** Pure SwiftUI for iPhone, iPad, Mac, Apple Watch, Apple TV and Vision Pro. Native from day one, no web wrappers, no Unity.
- **Privacy-first, by build, not by claim.** Zero third-party SDKs. No analytics, no ads, no tracking. Saves sync through iCloud and nowhere else.
- **Real 24-hour offline progression.** A compressed simulation runs when you open the app, XP, items, even combat with food and death risk. Not a two-hour AFK token.

- **Clean monetization.** Free download, a single \$9.99 unlock. No energy bars, no premium currency, no gacha.

Current status

In TestFlight beta now, the core loop (skills, combat, equipment, offline progression) is working, and the focus is a 1.0 worth your time: passive items, consumables, achievements, leaderboards and a completion book. Launching free on iPhone, iPad and Mac.



The same save on iPhone: a live fight on the coast, and the offline-progress report waiting when you reopen the app.

Get into the beta

Newsletter subscribers get first access to Tideward TestFlight builds and a direct line into shaping it. Drop your email at tideward.app/install, or subscribe at blog.manugames.com and tell me you're a factory-game person.

Links

Every game and project in this guide, direct.

Factory games

- Factorio factorio.com
- Factorio: Space Age factorio.com/buy-space-age
- Satisfactory satisfactorygame.com
- Shaperez 2 store.steampowered.com/app/2162800
- Dyson Sphere Program store.steampowered.com/app/1366540
- Mindustry mindustrygame.github.io
- Foundry store.steampowered.com/app/983870
- Captain of Industry captain-of-industry.com
- StarRupture store.steampowered.com/app/1631270
- Modulus: Factory Automation store.steampowered.com/app/2779120

Idle & incremental games

- Tideward (mine!) tideward.app
- Kaizen: A Factory Story store.steampowered.com/app/2275490
- The Farmer Was Replaced store.steampowered.com/app/2060160
- Unnamed Space Idle store.steampowered.com/app/2471100
- Berry Bury Berry store.steampowered.com/app/3370870
- Legends of Dragaea: Idle Dungeons store.steampowered.com/app/2712380
- Melvor Idle melvoridle.com
- Synergism store.steampowered.com/app/3552310
- Antimatter Dimensions store.steampowered.com/app/1399720
- Bitburner store.steampowered.com/app/1812820
- Cookie Clicker store.steampowered.com/app/1454400
- NGU Idle store.steampowered.com/app/1147690
- Nodebuster store.steampowered.com/app/3107330

The Assembly Line

- Newsletter blog.manugames.com
- Tideward tideward.app
- Manu Games manugames.com
- Discord community discord.gg/hw6w93astV

About The Assembly Line

A free newsletter covering factory games, idle games, and everything in between, twice a week, from someone who actually plays them and ships them. Every issue:

- **The Conveyor**, the biggest factory-game story of the week, with an opinionated take.
- **Patch Notes Roundup**, quick-hit updates across Factorio, Satisfactory, Shapex 2, Dyson Sphere, Foundry, Captain of Industry and the under-covered indies.
- **The Idle Corner**, idle and incremental news, new releases, r/incremental favorites.
- **The Deep Dive**, strategy guides, head-to-head comparisons and design teardowns.
- **Tideward Dev Log**, a build-in-public diary from making a premium idle RPG for Apple.

Written by Manu Games, a one-person studio in Waynesville, North Carolina. Maker of Tideward, publisher of The Assembly Line.

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A new issue twice a week. No spam, no fluff, just factory and idle game news from someone in the trenches.

Share this guide with someone hunting for their next game.

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